

Golden Goose of Referrals

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Golden Idea

The Golden Goose is a reference from a classic fairy tale where a goose lays golden eggs, symbolizing a source of continuous and reliable wealth. It represents the idea of having a self-sustaining asset that produces valuable outcomes repeatedly without exhausting itself, often used metaphorically to describe something that brings endless prosperity or opportunities.

This video is going to teach you how to raise a Golden Goose of Referrals — so you can get an endless supply of them.

Importance

What's the main reason this idea is important to understand?

- This is our greatest tool (behind writing an amazing resume) to land that first interview — there really isn't much else other than resume + referral.
- We've already discussed your resume, so now it's time to talk about referrals.



What is a Referral?

In the context of software engineering job applications, a referral typically refers to a recommendation or endorsement from a current employee of the company to which you are applying. This means that someone within the company, usually a software engineer or another employee, submits your resume or application to the internal hiring system or directly speaks to the hiring manager or recruiter on your behalf.

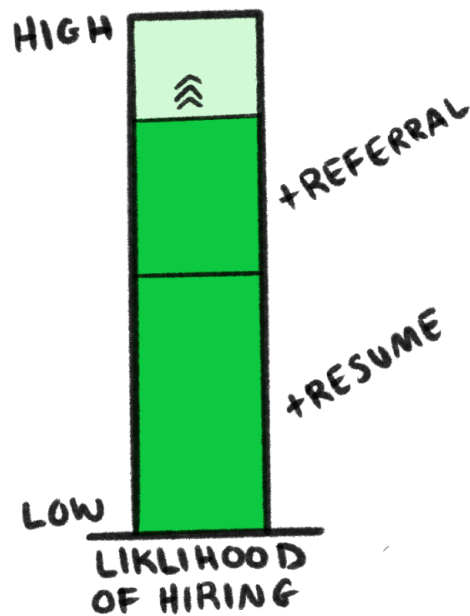
Why Do We Need Referrals?

- Deindividuation, social proof
- Turn a cold application into a warm one
- What is the impact? (4x likelihood)
 - According to a study by Jobvite, referred candidates are 4 times more likely to be hired compared to candidates who apply without a referral.



Where Do Referrals Fit into the Application Process?

This diagram shows that your Resume + Referral leads into everything else, and based on that, they decide whether to give you the interview or not. It's a one-two punch situation.



Your referral is more powerful the smaller the company is — but they are always important!





How Often Do You Need Referrals?

You should go for a referral 100% of the time — I don't want to see you submit an application without a referral.

- However, this is a little nuanced. Realistically, you won't be able to get a referral to every single company — aim for 100%, and walk away with 50-75%.
- If you aim lower than 100%, you'll end up barely getting 20-30%. This is how it works. In this game, you always land lower than you aim — but you still need to aim high to land high.
 - You can't just arbitrarily pick 75% of them to try for, because you don't know which 75% will work out. You need to attempt to land a referral for ALL companies.

“The Law of Averages” or **“The Law of Large Numbers.”** This idea suggests that to achieve a high success rate, you must make a large number of attempts because you can't predict which specific attempts will succeed. By aiming for 100% and trying for every opportunity, you naturally increase your chances of success due to the probabilistic nature of the outcomes.

The fundamental issue is impatience.

The biggest issue which you will experience is impatience — a lot of students believe in referrals, and they try for them, but they get impatient and submit the application early (without waiting long enough or trying hard enough). This screws them in the long run.

Why? Two reasons:

- **“fear of missing out” (FOMO)**. FOMO is the anxiety that an exciting or interesting event may currently be happening elsewhere, often aroused by posts seen on social media. In the context of job applications, it manifests as the **fear of missing an opportunity** if one doesn’t act immediately, leading to premature decisions like applying without a referral.

- **“Action Bias,”** which is the tendency to favor action over inaction, even when inaction would lead to a better outcome. In this case, students might feel a compulsion to act (i.e., submit their application) because it gives them a sense of control and accomplishment, even if waiting for a referral would significantly increase their chances of success. **Action bias often occurs because taking action feels like progress, alleviating the anxiety of doing nothing**, even if it’s counterproductive in the long run.
 - It is better to apply to less jobs with a referral than more jobs without one. Sniper vs shotgun, my friend.
 - The more experienced you are, the more you can apply without referrals, but referrals are an essential tool in our arsenal at this stage.



✉ What Are the Different Kinds of Referrals?

- **System (Strong or Weak)**
 - Special Application Link
 - Referral Code
- **Hiring manager / recruiter email — what is the difference?**
 - A recruiter is responsible for **sourcing, attracting, and screening potential candidates** for job openings, managing the initial stages of the hiring process, and coordinating interviews. They work across multiple roles and departments to ensure a steady pipeline of qualified applicants.
 - On the other hand, a hiring manager is typically the person within the department or team where the vacancy exists. **They define the job requirements, interview shortlisted candidates, and make the final hiring decision.** The hiring manager also oversees the new hire's integration into the team and their ongoing performance. In essence, recruiters find and present candidates, while hiring managers select and manage them.
 - You contact or someone at the company contacts them for you!
- **Tactics:** At this point you should understand what a referral is, the value of it, and our general strategy. I'm now going to teach you the tactics about how to obtain a referral in the most effective way possible.



1. How Networking Relates To Referrals

You should have finished [Money Grows On Trees: Networking 101](#) — in that video, I taught you how to use LinkedIn to grow your network.

That's your cold application starting point — you start with a phone call from people at the company, and now I'll tell you how to convert that into a referral.

- But 9/10, you need to start with a phone call — later on, we'll discuss how to get referrals in some cases without a phone call, but the vast majority of the time it's easiest to do over a call.

2. Get referrals BEFORE applications open up.

Follow Application Cartography — start with the companies that are open of course, but once you're finished with those, you should be constantly networking to get referrals before they open.

- Why? Because once the application opens, time is of the essence.
 - Go through your list of companies → find 10 new ones each week → send your 100 connection requests to grow your network with those engineers → get on calls with some of them → acquire a referral EARLY

3. Informational Interview / Phone Call Script (20-30 mins) — Take Notes!

Opening Remarks: introduce yourself, thank them for getting on the call and taking time out of their schedule to help.

- Learn about company/values - resources - ask about their journey.
- Why did they pick that company? How do they like it so far? What's their history, background, and plans for the future?
- What is it like to work at their company / what is the culture?
- Interview process - how did they land that specific role?
- Grill them on the interview process. Applications, online assessments (questions, topics, etc.), interviews, offer, and then ask for any advice or strategy tips they have for someone who's interviewing there.
- When do these positions open up? Learn about timeline.
 - When were they hired?
 - Go for the referral.

You could say something like: *"This is all so helpful, and I really really appreciate the advice you're giving me — I know in this process that companies often get thousands of applicants to these roles, and it's very difficult to stand out from the crowd, so I was wondering if you'd be able to refer me when the position opens up. It would really really help out a lot!"*

4. Overcome Objections:

When they use these phrases:

1. **"The referral doesn't do much at my company."**
 - a. *"Totally understand — I expect that at big companies like yours a lot of people get referrals, so it might not make a huge difference. But it can't hurt, right? I get that in the end it might not change much, but in the off chance that it does, would you be able to submit one for me? It would really really help out!"*
2. **"I don't know what our referral process is / I haven't heard much about that, I'll have to look into it."**
 - a. *"Totally understand, makes complete sense, and I appreciate that. When do you think you'll be able to find out about the referral process? Is there someone you'll have to ask?"*

Get more commitment from them — if they verbally say they will refer you, it's unlikely that they just ghost or don't later on.

3. **"Sorry, at our company, we only really refer people who we work with closely."**
 - a. *"Of course, that makes complete sense, and I appreciate the time you took out to get on this call and help me with the interview process and tell me about your journey. Would it be possible to...."*

This one is really unlikely, and the hardest one to overcome because it's a straight up rejection — I just want to put it here to get it on your radar.

Use their response to get contact at the company.

4. **"My team doesn't hire interns/new grads/your role."**
 - a. *Makes complete sense, do you know of any other people who have worked with interns/new grads/role at all? Even if you've just heard of them at the company, if you could connect me with that person that would be extremely helpful — just to make sure my resume gets seen, you know how these applications go.*

5. Get Alternative Form of Contact

“Thank you, that would be amazing! Now, do you check LinkedIn super often? Or is there another way I can contact you that would work better, like email or phone number?”

Why? Because people will often not see your messages if you just stick to LinkedIn chat. You might have to, but it's best to get another form of contact.

Acquire additional connections at the company (intern coordinator, hiring manager, recruiter, software engineers, etc.)

Very important next step, and is what will drastically improve your chances if you can pull it off. Having a recruiting contact at the company is incredibly valuable. This is that hiring manager or recruiter email you want to go for.

“Thanks for that! Now, would it also be possible to connect me with a recruiter or hiring manager at the company who hires interns [or full-time role]? Again, mainly because I know that you guys probably get thousands of applications and I just want to make sure my resume at least gets looked at by someone.”

- Can even ask for their recruiter, person who hired them (if they're in your desired role).

In order of value, but go for 2/3!

Hiring Manager: best case, person who's hiring for THAT role itself.

Recruiter: someone who goes out and sources talent. Still great.

- Companies often have special recruiters for big CS schools, so if you go to a top 20 school for CS, ask about that!
- Additional Software Engineer
- On a team that has interns or new grads / then repeat the process with them.

What to do with these additional contacts?

You want to send them emails over and over again — mere exposure effect.

- If you have a recruiter email, send them an email letting them know you applied and just wanted to make sure your resume was looked at.
 - “Hi _____, my name is _____, and I'm a computer science student at [University]! I just applied for the [internship @ company] and

wanted to connect with you to follow up on my application and express enthusiasm for the role! Thank you.”

- If they can't find the recruiter, then you find one on LinkedIn and send it to them — the intern manager or coordinator.
 - Or ask them to connect you with any recruiter.
- Then, follow up every 1-2 weeks until you get the interview or get rejected.
 - Questions Via Chat
- Sometimes, they won't even give you the call, and will instead ask to send your questions via chat — if they don't have time for the call.
 - Here's a script for that:
 - *“Totally understand where you're coming from! My main questions are:”*
 - *“What was your interview / application process for the [position]? I would love to learn how [company name] recruits and interview for that role.”*
 - *“When the application opens up, would it be possible to submit a referral for me? I know how companies like [company name] tend to get thousands of applications for [role], and I just want to make sure I have a fighting chance of at least getting my resume seen. I'd really appreciate it!”*
 - If Interns Are Finished...
 - If you're going for internships, sometimes you'll be connecting with interns at that company.
 - Often, those interns will be finished (if it's not the summer) — in that case, ask them to introduce you to their manager via email.
 - Then, do everything above with their manager.
 - Direct Ask Without Phone Call
 - People have sometimes asked me if they should just ask directly for the referral via chat and not go for the phone call.
 - There are two reasons why I tend to avoid doing this:
 - Foot-in-the-Door: You're more likely to succeed if you do in a smaller step process.
 - You miss out on all the other benefits of the phone call — knowledge, additional contact, long term connection, etc.
 - Those 20 mins are so high ROI is unimaginable — stop seeing it as annoying or a waste of time.
 - Girlfriend's Netflix Story + My Shopify Story.

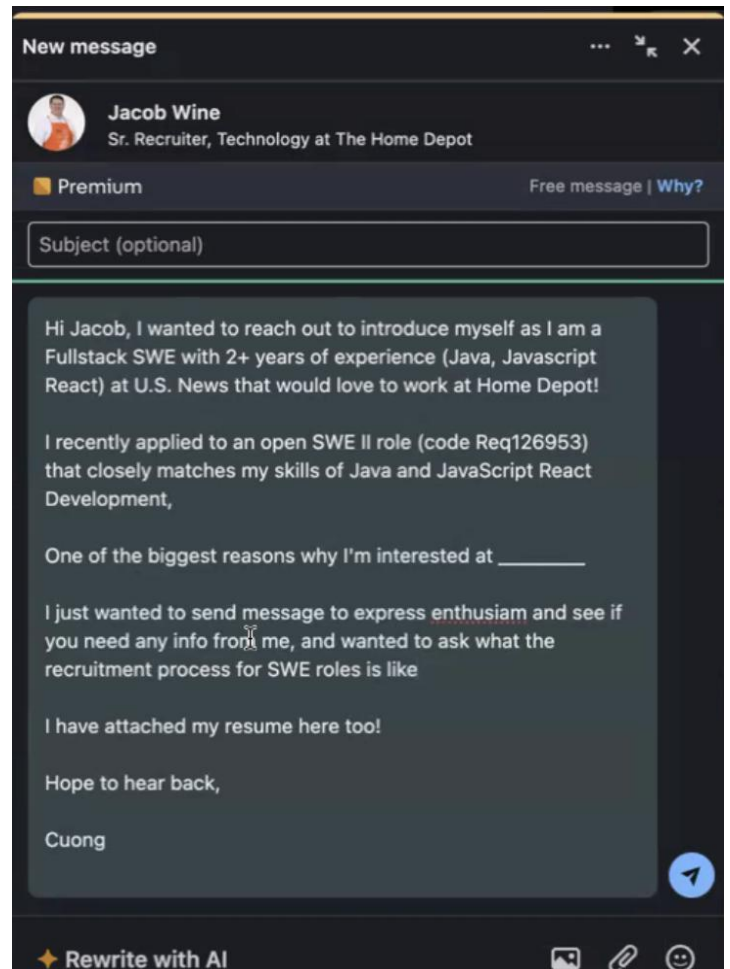
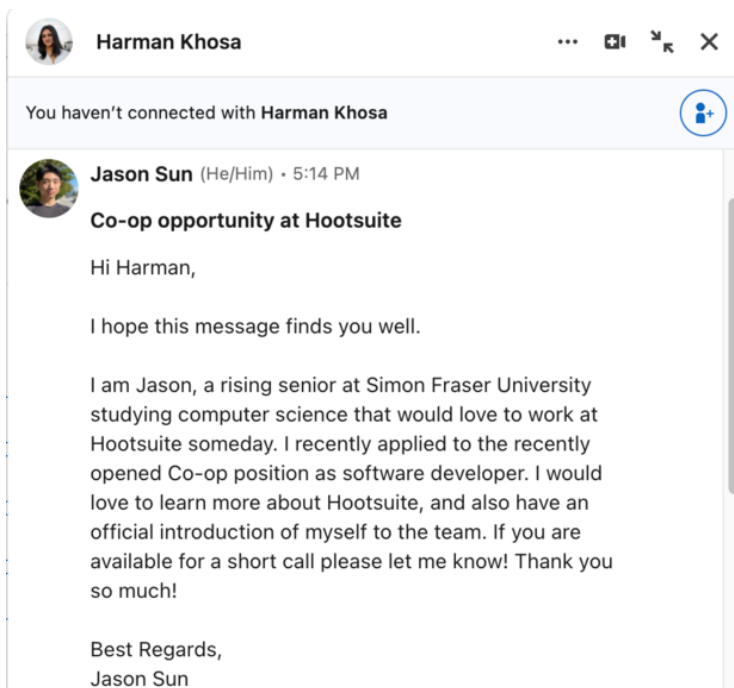
Now, the only exception is sometimes for big companies people will give out referrals via chat — it happens a decent amount, and if they offer it, then take it.

AM

If you really want to blind message, then do it for big companies and never for small ones.

For smaller companies, since you have less people to work with, you'll need to put more work into each step.

- You can sometimes cold message recruiters and it can sometimes work.



6. Success Rates

- 15-20% Connection Acceptance — this goes up based on your profile / message.
- 20-30% Call Acceptance Rate.
- 80%-90% Referral Acceptance Rate.



💡 The Fortune is in The Follow-Up

At every stage, you **MUST** follow up if you don't get a response. Every time.

Very often, people will accept your connection request and not respond — this is expected, and just fine.

If someone agrees to refer you and then you ask and they don't respond, keep on following up! Never expect a response on the first message, expect it on the 10th.

Use the script in Money Grows On Trees: Networking 101.

I know someone who got an Apple internship because they met a recruiter at a career fair, got the recruiter information, and followed up 7 times before he got the first interview.

He got that internship, turned it into a return offer, and is starting in September.

You **MUST** follow up on EVERY job application you submit. Every single one.

Timing

How long should you wait to apply without a referral?

- You need to assess how volatile the application itself is, and it's based on how prestigious the company is.

Key: Get the referral beforehand + avoid this issue.

- FAANG — 24-48h before applying.
- Google 48h, Meta 48h, Amazon Longer (72h).
- Medium — name brand but less prestigious — 2-4 days.
- Low — 5-7 days.

It is better to apply to fewer places because the application expired with referrals than to apply to more without referrals!

Still go for a referral even if you already cold applied.

What Info To Send For Referral

- When someone agrees to refer you, you'll need to send them some information — here's what to do there.
- Fill out this Google Doc for them, and then add your info in the folder that the doc is in as well as your resume.

Extra Notes

Sometimes, people have a team-specific application link. That can be extra helpful — I believe TikTok does this, and you'll want to ask if the referral is coming from someone on a team that hires new grads/interns.



🎓 Referral Strategy Q&A: Course Extension

Welcome to the *extended Q&A section* of the Referral Strategy module! These are the real, nuanced questions that students ask all the time — and here are Aman's answers based on coaching hundreds of students into top software roles.

This section is designed to:

- Answer **common tactical questions**
- Clarify **edge cases** and **decision-making**
- Help you **internalize** referral strategy

☑ **Section 1: If You've Already Got a Referral**

Q: What do you do if you already got a referral and other people are responding? Should you still schedule a call with them?

A: Yes, absolutely. Schedule a call with anyone who's willing. Multiple connections at a company can help you:

- Get referred again for new roles when they open up
- Connect with hiring managers or recruiters
- Gain insights into the interview process
- Build a longer-term network

Calls are rarely a bottleneck. If you're overloaded (20+ in one week), prioritize. Otherwise, always take the call.

Section 2: Chat-Only Responses

Q: What if they say, "just ask me over LinkedIn chat"?

A: If they prefer chat, here's what to say:

1. Ask about their journey: "How was your experience getting the role at [Company]? What was the interview/application process like?"
2. Then ask: "Would you be open to submitting a referral for me? I'd really appreciate it — I know how competitive the process is, and that would mean a lot."

We cover this in more detail in the "Questions via Chat" script in the Golden Goose module.

Section 3: Who Can Refer You?

Q: Can people in other departments refer you?

A: Yes. While referrals from software engineers are best, anyone at the company can technically refer you. The same strategy applies.

Q: Can non-software engineers refer you?

A: Yep. If that's who you have access to, go for it. Recruiters, PMs, designers — all can submit internal referrals.

Q: Can interns refer you?

A: Only if they are currently interns. If they've already finished, ask them to introduce you to their manager.

Q: What about independent contractors or vendors?

A: They usually don't have referral access, but you can use them to get intros to full-time employees who do.

Q: Should I reach out to Canadians or people in the US if I'm applying from Canada?

A: Reach out to both — optimize for people who are currently in the location of the role you're applying to.

Q: Is two years too long to ask for a referral from a past internship?

A: No. If you had a good relationship and they're still at the company, you can still reach out. Just reintroduce yourself first.

Q: If I'm reaching out to interns or alumni in my age group, how do I transition to the ask?

A: Keep it casual. Ask about their experience, then say: "Would you be open to referring me? Totally fine if not — just figured I'd ask!"

12 34 Section 4: Volume & Metrics

Q: Is getting 17 referrals a good number?

A: That's a great start! Aim for:

- 15–20 referrals per month
- 5+ referrals per week

This compounds to over 100 in 6 months — and it's rare not to land interviews at that level.

Q: For a big company with many alumni, how many should I reach out to?

A: Start with 10. If no responses in a few days, send to 10 more. Keep expanding your wave.

Section 5: Timing & Sequence

Q: Should I apply before getting a referral?

A: Try to get a referral first. But:

- For FAANG: wait 2–3 days max
- For mid-size companies: 5–7 days
- If nothing, apply

Q: Job posted 2 hours ago — wait or apply?

A: Try to get the referral. Better to apply with a referral even if it's 1–2 days later.

Q: What if I already applied — should I still get a referral?

A: Yes. Referrals can still boost your app. Don't reapply under a new email. Just ask them to refer you under the original.

Q: Person only free for a call next week but app is open now. Should I wait?

A: Ask them to refer you via chat now, and still do the call next week.

Q: If warm leads don't refer after 2 months, what then?

A: Switch to cold leads. Start sending out connection requests.

Q: Got an internship already — should I still network?

A: Yes! Stack referrals early. Roles open fast and often without warning.

Section 6: Messaging & Communication Strategy

Q: Should I mention a referral in the initial connection message?

A: No. Keep the connection message short and low-pressure. You can make the ask after they accept.

Q: How personal should my connection messages be?

A: A little context helps. Mention a shared background (school, major, hometown) if you can.

Q: Should I send a request directly to a hiring manager or go through employees?

A: Start with engineers or alumni, then go to hiring managers if needed.

Q: Should I use LinkedIn or ask for email/phone?

A: Try to get email & phone ASAP, and use Calendly.

Q: Can I follow up every day?

A: No. Follow up every 2-4 days. More than that feels spammy.

Q: Should I follow up with people who never accepted my connection?

A: Yes potentially — you might be able to withdraw the request after a week and re-send it with a message.

Section 7: Strategy & Prioritization

Q: Should I get multiple referrals per company?

A: Get 1–2 max per role. Don't submit multiple referrals for wildly different roles.

Q: Is it worth reaching out to people after applying?

A: Yes. Many can give retrospective referrals or help get your resume seen.

Q: Got one referral, others responded — should I ignore them?

A: No. Talk to them. Build more connections, and ask for intros to hiring managers.

Q: For small companies with no replies, should I just apply?

A: Yes. Try a few messages, wait ~1 week, then just apply.

Q: No alumni — who do I reach out to?

A: Start with hometown or shared background — anything that signals familiarity.

Q: Why are referrals such a big deal?

A: 4x more likely to get hired, 10x more likely to be seen by a human. They cut through ATS noise.

Q: Do referrals speed up hiring?

A: Yes. Even if rejected, they get your application looked at.

Q: What if they won't refer you due to not knowing you well?

A: Say: "Totally understand. Would you be open to connecting me with the recruiter or hiring manager so I can follow up directly?"

Section 8: Call Logistics

Q: Wait until they're back in office? Schedule for next week?

A: Talk ASAP. Don't delay.

Q: What if they decline the call?

A: Go straight for the referral via chat.

Q: Startup founder call — how should I prepare?

A: Treat it like a behavioral interview. Do research and clearly state your interest.

Section 9: Special Cases

Q: Does using the school job portal count as a warm lead?

A: No. Always try to pair it with a referral if possible.

Q: Should I connect on LinkedIn before meeting them at an event?

A: Yes. But if not, follow up immediately after the event.

Q: What if someone won't share the recruiter's contact?

A: Ask for their LinkedIn at least. Then message them directly.



Q: How do I message professors or research contacts?

A: Use the email guide & try to setup a call for general advice.

Section 10: Tools & Tactics

Q: Can I use ChatGPT to write messages?

A: Absolutely — but review and make sure they sound human.

Q: What if my messages aren't working?

A: Come to office hours or post in Skool for feedback.

Q: How do I track referrals and follow-ups?

A: Use a spreadsheet. We're releasing one soon inside the Accelerator.

Q: What if the company has no open roles?

A: Ask: "Would you be open to referring me once a role opens up?"

Let us know in Skool if you have more questions you'd like added to this FAQ.